The Sacramentary

(LIBER SACRAMENTORUM)

Historical & Liturgical Notes on the Roman Missal

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SUNDAY BEFORE THE FEAST OF ALL SAINTS

Feast of the Kingship of Our Lord Jesus Christ*

The Messianic Kingdom is essentially the universal and glorious reign established by Christ for the glory of God and the salvation of the world. The Holy Scriptures are clear on this point, and whilst they describe with great reserve the character of the "Servant of Jahvè wounded for our iniquities," they are eloquent in telling us of the glories of the King whose brow is crowned with many crowns, and who bears written on his royal mantle the title of *Rex regum et Dominus dominantium.*

The holy Sacrifice and the divine Office form the solemn daily tribute paid by the Church to Christ, who is both High-priest and King. The very feasts of the Liturgy such as the Epiphany, Easter and the Ascension are intended to glorify those mysteries in which Christ appears to us more especially under the figure of a King.

It is as a King that on the Epiphany he is sought by the Magi from the distant Eastern lands, and that he receives the firstfruits of the adoration soon to be rendered to him by all the powers of the earth.

At Easter he bends beneath his feet all the forces which are arrayed against him: *curvat imperia*, and opens the Messianic reign by triumphing over death and Satan. It is as King and supreme arbiter of the earth's destiny that Christ, heeding no temporal authority, sends his apostles to preach freely in every place *Evangelium Regni. Data est mihi omnis potestas in caelo et in terra. Ite ergo; docete omnes gentes, baptizantes eos.*

Lastly, on Ascension Day we contemplate him seated on the throne of the Godhead at the right hand of the Father, and we say in the words of the Creed: *cujus regni non erit finis.*

Nevertheless, in spite of the solemn affirmations of the Kingship of Christ contained in Scripture and in Holy Liturgy, for more than fifty years, a pernicious heresy has spread throughout the civilized world which some call liberalism and others "laicisme." This error has many aspects, but consists chiefly in the denial of the supremacy of God and the Church over Society and the State. The latter officially declares itself to be independent of any other authority (a free Church in a free State), when it does not go further and claim divine prerogatives requiring like Moloch of old the sacrifice of every other right both of the individual and the family. The State is the supreme expression of the absolute.

As in the past many liturgical feasts originated from the ardour with which the Faith of the Church opposed certain errors then in vogue, so now, too, the Apostolic See has considered that the most efficacious way of making the condemnation of "laicisme" widely known was that of instituting a solemn feast of the Messianic Kingship of Christ. This forms at once a protest and an act of reparation to atone for that idolatry of the State which has joined in a great conspiracy: *reges terrae et principes . . . in unum, adversus Dominum et adversus Christum eius.*

At first many different dates were proposed by liturgists: the Sunday within the Octave of the Epiphany, the Ascension, the Octave of the feast of the Sacred Heart, but it seemed wiser not to join this feast to one already in existence but to give it a particular character of its own and a special place in the Missal. Finally the new festival was fixed on the Sunday preceding the feast of All Saints in order to connect it with the Office of November 1, and with the thoughts inspired by that collective feast of all the saints, the veneration of the Heavenly Jerusalem and the court of the King of Glory. It is fitting that the Liturgy, drawing near to the end of the cycle of Sundays after Pentecost, which represents the labours and struggles of earthly life, before turning her thoughts to the various choirs of the *ecclesia primitivorum* and the Heavenly City, should pay homage to him who is the cause and the end of that glory, and to whom the saints all offer their crowns and sing their joyful Alleluia.

This is the reason why in the Office of All Saints the first responsory of Matins describes the throne of the Omnipotent One, the hem of whose garment rests upon the holy temple in sign of sanctification. *Vidi Dominum sedentem super solium excelsum et elevatum . . . et ea quae sub ipso erant replebant templum.*

The Introit is taken from the hymn which St John heard in heaven: "Worthy is the Lamb that was slain to receive power, and divinity, and wisdom, and strength, and honour. To him be glory and empire for ever and ever."

The exaltation of Jesus Christ is, according to St Paul, in proportion to the humiliation he endured in obedience to his Heavenly Father. Wherefore St John before speaking of the glory of the Lamb recalls his sacred Passion, and says that he was immolated and slain.

The first verse of Psalm lxxi follows, which is distinctly Messianic: "Give the King thy judgement, O God: and to the King's Son thy justice."

This is the Messianic office conferred upon Jesus in the

world. He as "splendour of the substance of the Father" will govern the House of David until such time as he shall have conquered the enemy and established the kingdom of God in peace. Death and the devil having been overcome, the temporal mission of Christ will end, and he like a glorious conqueror will lay at his Father's feet the sceptre and the crown, the trophy of his victory.

Collect: "Almighty everlasting God, who hast willed to restore all things in thy beloved Son, the King of the whole creation; mercifully grant that all the communities of the nations that are scattered by the wound of sin may be subjected unto his most sweet dominion."

This Collect is inspired by the words of St Paul, and therefore is full of meaning. The unity of the human race, indeed that of the whole of creation, has been ruined by sin which is a disruptive force. God has willed to restore the original unity and has done so through Jesus Christ, whom he has established as the centre and end of creation, the new Adam from whom all the peoples of the earth can receive life, unity, and grace.

The Lesson is taken from the Epistle to the Colossians (i, 12–20) where St Paul describes the primacy of Christ over all creation, which finds in him the object of its existence. This primacy of Christ is founded on the hypostatic union of his human nature with the divine nature in the person of the Word, but it is universal and includes not man alone, but also the angels who derive grace and glory from him. His primacy concerns the Church especially, for Christ's dominion over her is similar to that which in the human body is exercised by the head over the other members.

The Gradual is taken from Psalm lxxi and describes the extent and the glory of the Kingdom of Christ. "He shall rule from sea to sea, and from the river even unto the ends of the earth. And all the Kings of the earth shall adore him; all nations shall serve him. Alleluia."

This prophecy is gradually being fulfilled as the Church extends her peaceful conquests among the pagan nations, and the Gospel of the kingdom will be preached throughout the whole earth. In the history of the Church this kingdom of Christ is complete and absolute *de jure*, but is still opposed and incomplete *de facto*. It will be entire, final, and glorious at the day of judgement, when, having conquered death, Christ will fulfil his office as judge, condemning the wicked and calling the just to the immortal life of the blessed resurrection.

The alleluiatic verse is taken from the passage in Daniel (vii, 14), when the prophet describes the various reigns dividing

the history of humanity into different periods: "His power is an eternal power, which shall not be taken away; and his kingdom shall not be made void."

It is easy to recognize the partial accomplishment of this prophecy even now, if we compare the history of the Church already covering nearly two thousand years with those of other empires and dynasties. All these have passed like the leaves which unfold in the Spring and fall with the coming of Autumn.

In the double chant after the Epistle the threefold catholicity of the Kingdom of Christ is placed before us. First that of place: *a mari usque ad mare*, thus embracing the whole world. Then that of the subjects: *omnes reges . . . omnes gentes* including all men, be they kings and princes or wretched pariahs humbled in the dust. Finally the universality of the ages: *potestas aeterna . . . non auferetur*, that is to say a power which shall never end.

The Gospel is taken from St John (xviii, 33–37) and contains the solemn declaration made by Christ before Pilate concerning the nature and origin of his kingdom. This kingdom does not depend upon the world: *regnum meum non est hinc*, but it comprehends the world. Jesus does not come to dethrone the sovereigns of the earth, and to take from them the domains over which they rule. He comes, rather, to give to human society the last and most perfect rule, and lays down in the Gospel the supreme laws of truth and justice to guide both rulers and subjects in the exercise of their mutual duties. God is the supernatural end of man. It is the obvious task of civilized society and of those who govern it to collaborate with the Church and to help her, always of course within the bounds of civil authority, to accomplish with greater security and ease her divine mission of enlightening, guiding, and governing souls, establishing in them the kingdom of Christ.

This supremacy of the Catholic Church and the Pope over nations and their monarchs formed part of the international law of Christian states in the Middle Ages. Therefore it happened more than once that the Popes deposed kings who were unworthy of their office and released their subjects from the oath of fidelity by which they were bound.

The Offertory is taken from Psalm ii. To the nations and the kings who rise up against his divine design of establishing the Messianic Kingdom for the salvation of the world, Christ shows the solemn deed of investiture which he has received from his Father: "Ask of me, and I will give thee the Gentiles for thy inheritance, and the ends of the earth for thy possession."

Secret: "We offer unto thee, O Lord, the Host of man's reconciliation; grant, we beseech thee, that he whom we immolate in these present sacrifices, may grant unto all nations the gifts of unity and peace, even Jesus Christ our Lord thy Son."

The Preface is proper to the feast and has some of the grandeur and lyrical quality of the ancient Prefaces. *Vere dignum . . . Qui Unigenitum Filium tuum Dominum nostrum Jesum Christum, sacerdotem aeternum et universorum regem, oleo exsultationis unxisti; ut seipsum in ara Crucis hostiam immaculatam et pacificam offerens, redemptionis humanae sacramenta perageret; ut suo subjectis imperio omnibus creaturis, aeternum et universale regnum immensae tuae traderet maiestati; regnum veritatis et vitae; regnum sanctitatis et gratiae; regnum justitiae, amoris et pacis. Et ideo . . .*

The conception of Christ as Pontiff and King who reconquers and restores to his Heavenly Father the realm of creation which had been taken from him by sin, in order that God might eternally be all in all, is borrowed from St Paul. The compiler, however, has the merit of having given to his liturgical composition the lyrical character of a triumphant hymn of thanksgiving so characteristic of the primitive eucharistic *Hymnus*, as our anaphora of the consecration was then called.

The Antiphon for the Communion is a prelude to the final effect of the eucharistic Sacrifice which ends with the divine blessing. At the moment of Holy Communion Jesus is enthroned in the faithful heart and fills it with his presence: He who is "Blessed" among all and through whom, according to the promise given by God to Abraham, all the nations of the earth shall be blessed. Psalm xxviii: "The Lord shall sit as King for ever, the Lord shall bless his people with peace."

Post-Communion: "Having received the food of immortality, we beseech thee, O Lord, that we who glory in our warfare under the banners of Christ the King may come to reign with him for ever in his heavenly dwelling-place: who with thee."

The Royal Standard of Jesus Christ is the Cross: *Dicite in nationibus: regnavit a ligno Deus;* for the kingdom of Christ is that of obedience, humility and sacrifice.

OCTOBER 31

Vigiliary Mass of All Saints

The celebration of a festival in honour of all the Saints at this season of the year, appears to have passed from the Gallican into the Roman Liturgy. As a collective feast of all